

3.4 Current Generation Consoles

The current generation of consoles include the PlayStation 2, the Xbox and the GameCube. This generation rode on the success of the original PlayStation and used it to sell even more consoles. The present crop of consoles is on the verge of obsolescence as the next-gen consoles are all ready for release.

PlayStation

Sony decided to usher in the next generation of their PlayStation in 2000 with the PlayStation 2. Like we've said, right at the outset, Sony ensured it would be a success by enabling backward compatibility with games from the original PlayStation. When launched, it did go through a rough patch: hardware shortages left consumers frustrated, and game developers complained about the difficulty to develop games for the system.

At this point, it was the backward compatibility and support for DVDs that was selling the PS2. Eventually the games did come, and boy, did they make an impact! The summer of 2001 saw one blockbuster after another and pushed the PS2 miles ahead of the competition (the Xbox and the GameCube).

Sony has now stopped manufacturing the PS2, as it prepares to usher in the third generation of the PlayStation with the PS3.

GameCube

Nintendo was one of two major competitors for the PS2, with its GameCube. Launched in 2001, the console is shaped like a cube—hence the name. It comes in a number of colours and uses the GameCube Optical Disc instead of CDs. The GameCube Optical Disc is a proprietary format, with the disk only 8 cm in diameter, and a storage capacity of 1.5 GB. The GameCube also came with the ability to connect to a Nintendo GameBoy, a handheld gaming device. Although it has done well, largely due to aggressive pricing, the GameCube has fallen behind the two giants of the industry today.